Week 17

JOURNEY

JOURNEY: ADVOCATES® · LEADER HANDOUT · UNIT 5 · LESSON 1

Miracles

BIG IDEA

Miracles are less something to prove than signposts: because miracles happen, they point to the God who acts. This week helps students define a real miracle, weigh what science can and can't explain, and consider that God can still work miracles today.

Key points from the Leader Video

1. The aim isn't only to prove miracles exist but to show they point to God; 1 Kings 18, Elijah and the prophets of Baal, puts God's sovereign power on display.
2. The intro experience asks for the most improbable event in history, so students can tell a biblical miracle from a lucky parking spot or the "miracle of birth."
3. For a storyteller, consider a trusted student who has witnessed something like a healing; the speaker recalls a student whose mission-trip experience shaped her life.
4. Students are conditioned to assume science explains everything. Keep a healthy balance: some things can be explained, but science can't explain the supernatural.
5. Expect "Why don't I see miracles like the lame man Peter and John healed?" We can't say they don't happen today; God still has the power to do them.
6. In small groups, note who is convinced miracles are possible and have happened, ask what it would take, and walk gently with anyone asking why God healed someone else.

SCRIPTURE IN THE VIDEO 1 Kings 18

FOR YOU

Before club: think it through yourself.

1. Do I tend to explain things away before I consider that God might be at work?
2. Where have I seen God act in a way I couldn't explain, and have I told anyone about it?
3. How will I respond when a student asks why God healed someone else but not them?

ASK YOUR GROUP

In small group: questions to ask your students.

1. How would you define a miracle, and how is it different from something that's just unlikely or lucky?
2. What do you think science can explain, and where do you think its explanations stop?
3. What would it take for you to be convinced that miracles are possible today?
4. Have you or someone you know experienced something you'd call a miracle? What made it feel that way?
5. If God can do miracles, how do you make sense of the times He doesn't seem to?

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WEEK 17 · LEADER VIDEO

The full transcript

The talk from this week's Leader Video, lightly edited for reading. Times point back to that moment in the video.

Miracles point to God

0:05 So it's Unit 5, Lesson 1, and we get to talk about miracles. As you start to prepare for this week, I don't want you necessarily just thinking, "I've got to prove to my students that miracles exist." We're going to show a little bit of that, but more so that because there are miracles, it points to the fact that God exists. We start off — if you just look at what the students are going to study in their Bible — we actually chose 1 Kings 18 for that very reason.

0:40 When you look at that particular miracle, the miracle of Elijah and the prophets of Baal, and a huge fire came down and ignited the sacrifice, and how that represented God's sovereign power — that miracle is just another way we can see it. Among all the things that Jesus did, all the things in the Bible, this is a really, really cool example of how God showed up and performed a miracle so that we can see exactly who God is.

The intro experience

1:14 As students begin this week and start reading, the intro experience is going to walk them through what to think about when it comes to miracles and what that looks like. We ask them specifically: what's the most improbable event in human history? Just have them think through, what would be an improbable event? Things like this: it's not likely that if I stepped outside right now I'd get struck by lightning. That's probably not going to happen. If I walked outside and a meteor just crashed on earth and annihilated me and everybody around — probably not going to happen, but it is an improbable event, the same as a miracle.

1:54 So the intro experience for the students is really to get them thinking through: when we talk about a miracle, what are we talking about? You might get some answers when you start talking with your students. You might actually get things like, "Is it a miracle that when you're out shopping during the Christmas season, a parking spot right by the door opened up? Is that a miracle and a sign from God that you got that parking space?" Probably not. Is that a miracle? Is it a miracle when a child is born? We call it the miracle of birth, but is that really a miracle? We're talking about miracles that we see in Scripture. That's where you want your students to start to think through and get an idea of what exactly we're talking about when we're talking about a miracle.

Choosing your storyteller

2:41 So let's talk for a second about your storyteller. It might have been difficult up to this point, and it may be difficult moving forward, to find the perfect person for your storyteller. You might have had to search high and low, and maybe this is one of those spots where you're thinking, "I really don't know exactly who I want for a storyteller." For this week, I might suggest

you use a student. Find a student who maybe has witnessed a miracle — maybe a miraculous healing.

3:14 I once had a student whose story was hard to refute, because she was such a trusted and honest student. We knew that she was telling the truth and that her experience was real. She was on a missions trip in Africa, and she was praying over a young girl, and this young girl's legs were not the same somehow. She can't explain it, and she would tell you today that she has no idea what exactly happened or how it happened.

3:45 But she knew some kind of miracle happened. As they were praying, it felt to her like this little girl's leg grew enough that they were the same. She told me, "Mr. Kozak, I don't know if this is real. I don't know if this is true, but I feel like this happened." She felt like she was a witness to an actual miracle, a little bit like what goes on in Scripture. None of us were there, and none of us can verify it, but it was a really fascinating story that helped students see the power of a miracle.

4:15 What she thought happened, what she saw happen, deeply impacted her. Today she still regularly goes to Africa and serves as a missionary there on and off, as much as she possibly can. That moment deeply impacted her, and I'm sure it impacted a lot of her fellow students. So this is one of those times when it might be really cool to find a student — maybe not with that crazy of a story, but a story nonetheless — a student who has witnessed a really divine, real miracle.

Large group time

4:43 As you get ready to engage students in large group time, I want you to keep one thing in mind. The misconception we've given you — that science can explain away miracles — is a very real reality in the life of our students. They're taught that, and they're conditioned to believe it. They're conditioned for that to be the default. Instead of thinking right away that something might be a miracle, they're conditioned to think right away that something can just be explained by science.

5:17 There should be a healthy balance, because there are a lot of things we might think are miracles that end up being able to be explained. But there are also a lot of things we think we can explain that really end up actually being a miracle. We really can't explain it as well as we think, and science doesn't provide that kind of explanation. Science can't explain the supernatural. So be aware, as you're preparing your lesson, and figure out: how do I communicate to students that miracles can actually happen, and the difference between what science can explain and what science cannot explain? That's going to compel students to start to think about whether miracles can really happen today, and maybe more importantly, whether miracles can happen right here and right now.

5:55 If you think about it, you're probably going to get some questions. This may happen more in your small group time, but you're going to get some questions. I can almost guarantee that students will start asking, well, if miracles can happen, how come I don't see miracles

happening in my space, in my culture, in my sphere of influence, in my family and those kinds of spaces, in the same way that we saw miracles in Scripture?

6:21 If you just look at the very early stages of Acts, Peter and John walk up to the temple. There's a lame man in front of the temple. He can't walk; he's never been able to walk. The Bible tells the story of Peter simply reaching his hand out and saying, "I don't have any money, but what I have I give you: in the name of Jesus, get up and walk." And the guy gets up and walks, and he's instantaneously healed. What's fascinating about that story is that this man had never been able to walk since birth — complete muscle atrophy in his legs — and all of a sudden his ankles become strong. He's jumping up and down. He's walking.

6:59 So students are going to ask the question: how come those miracles don't happen here today? Well, they might not happen in your city all that frequently, if ever. They might not happen in this country all that often or that frequently. But we don't know that they don't happen. They might, and it's likely that they do happen — maybe not to that degree, I don't know. But we can't discount it. We can't say they just don't happen. They might happen, and God has the power to make that happen if He so chooses. So miracles of a biblical proportion, I would argue, are still possible.

Small group time

7:39 While students are in small groups, encourage your small group leaders to really take time this week to ask — maybe to pry a little bit — to see whether your students are really convinced. Convinced of a couple of things. First, are they convinced that miracles are even possible at all, that it's even a possibility? Take note of that. Have your small group leaders actually take note of that, because it's going to become important next week when we start talking about the resurrection of Jesus. Are your students convinced that miracles are at least possible?

8:13 Number two: are your students convinced that miracles have happened in their midst — whether by their friends, or by people they know, or things they have read? Are they convinced that miracles have actually happened? Yes, first they have to be convinced that miracles are possible in order to be convinced that they have happened. Walk them through that process, and then, if they're not convinced, ask them what it would take.

8:40 What would it take to help them see the probability and the possibility of miracles all around them? Do they have to open up their view of God? Do they have to open up their view of who Jesus is and what the cross is all about? We'll get to that next week. What has to happen for them, do they think, in order to make miracles a reality in their mind, so that they can even see some of the things that God is up to?

When miracles get personal

9:06 One thing to keep in mind as you're navigating through this: although we talk a lot about the fact that miracles are possible and verifiable and that they do happen, and we see throughout Scripture that God works in mighty ways, and we want to boast that miracles happen all

throughout the world, this can also be a very, very personal thing. Miracles can bring up really, really important questions in the lives of our students.

9:33 How come God performed a miracle in this person's life, but not in my life? How come God healed this person, but not this person? It almost feels like God is picking and choosing. How does that work, and how do you walk with students through difficult times like that? I'm going to be honest with you: there's really not a specific answer that I can give you — a "Well, God does this because..." It's not there. But your job as a leader is to walk alongside your students and help them in their specific situations, to navigate those particular circumstances in those particular parts of their lives, so that they grow closer to Christ and not further away.